Kitchen Rush

High Concept Document

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GitHub repository: https://github.com/daggerscythe/kitchen-rush

Engine: Unreal Engine 5.8

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1. High Concept

1.1 High Concept Statement

Kitchen Rush: Grandma's Watch is a first-person cooking game where time only moves when you move. You inherit your grandmother's diner and her magic pocket watch, and one Friday dinner rush decides whether the diner survives. Walk, and the kitchen speeds up. Stand still, and it slows to a crawl, so you can pause in the middle of a disaster, study a frozen kitchen full of flying steaks and knives, and plan your next move. Survive from 5 PM to 10 PM without losing all your health or letting three customers leave unhappy.

1.2 Why Would People Want to Play It?

Why would people want to play this game, and why would they pick it over another one?

- **Chaos you can pause:** cooking games like *Overcooked* are frantic speed runs. Here, standing still slows the world, so the same chaos becomes a tactical puzzle you can read, plan, and then run in slow motion.
- **Throw it, catch it, serve it:** you can throw ingredients onto chopping boards, plates, and into pans and pots, and even throw a finished plate through the pass window. Catching what the clumsy waiter tosses and landing it straight on a plate earns extra tips, so showing off pays.
- **Every skill comes back in a new way:** the game teaches each skill safely, uses it as taught, and then forces a twist. The last twist is throwing a frying pan across the kitchen to knock a boiling soup pot off its burner.
- **Short and replayable:** one night is about 10 minutes, with a saved high score and a 1 to 3 star rating, so it is easy to go back for a better night.

2. The Player

2.1 The Player's Role

You play the grandchild who just inherited **The Second Hand**, your grandmother Nana's diner, which owes three months of rent. Tonight is the town's Friday dinner rush, your one shot to earn enough tips to keep the doors open. Nana also left you her brass pocket watch, which makes the world hold its breath whenever you stand still. The verbs of the game are: **walk** and **stop** (to control time), **chop**, **cook**, **plate**, and **serve**, **throw** and **catch** ingredients, **dodge** hazards, and **prioritize** which ticket or danger to handle first.

2.2 The Dream

This game fulfills a "dream of doing": "I wish I could stop time in the middle of a disaster and calmly fix it," mixed with the line cook's fantasy of running a perfect, fast kitchen. The player should feel like a calm master of chaos who stops, looks, and then moves exactly where and when it counts.

2.3 Expected Player

The expected player is 18 to 25 years old, like the other students in my class and my friends, and plays on a PC with a keyboard and mouse. They know WASD and mouse-look from first-person games, but they do not need to know *Superhot* or *Overcooked*. They like puzzles or casual cooking games and have about 10 minutes for one session. An expected rating would be about E10+ for cartoon peril: knives and fire hurt the cook, but there is no blood, gore, or enemies.

Using VandenBerghe's Five Domains of Play, the expected player is someone with:

- **Medium-to-high Challenge:** they like planning, timers, and being scored on precision, but the game stays forgiving with health regeneration, a friendly tutorial, and 3 strikes.
- **Medium-to-high Novelty:** the time rule is unusual for a cooking game, and every act adds a new twist on skills the player already knows.
- **Low Stimulation:** it is a solo game, so it fits players who like to play alone.
- **Low-to-medium Threat:** the kitchen is hectic and hazards hurt, but the tone is warm and silly, and it is never scary.

3. Genre

Kitchen Rush is mostly a **Simulation** (3D, first-person cooking and time management) mixed with **Puzzle** and **Action and Arcade**. It borrows the order-fulfillment style of *Overcooked* and the idea of time moving with the player from *Superhot*. Unlike most action games there are no enemies, because the real opponents are the clock and the kitchen itself.

4. Primary Gameplay Mode

The primary gameplay mode is **"Plan & Serve"**: one Friday dinner rush spent reading a slowed kitchen, planning a route, and then moving through it to cook and serve orders while dodging hazards.

- **Camera model:** first-person and dynamic. The held item and plate contents show at the bottom center of the HUD, and cook meters float above the pan and pot.
- **Interaction model:** avatar-based. You walk around the kitchen as the chef and interact with what you look at, using a crosshair that shows a prompt such as "E: Chop (2/4)".
- **Challenges:** cooking dishes in their perfect windows, beating each ticket's patience bar, catching or dodging what the waiter sends flying, and deciding what to do first when two or three things need you at once.
- **Actions:** move (WASD), look (mouse), crouch (Left Ctrl), interact (E: pick up, place, chop, serve, catch), and throw (hold the left mouse button to show the arc, release to throw).

5. Game Modes

Every mode, plus what moves the player between them, is described in full in Section 6 of the Game Script.

- **Tutorial (gameplay mode):** Act 1, "Nana's Notes". The shift clock is frozen at 5:00 PM and the tasks are step by step: learn the time rule, make a Tomato Salad, cook a steak, and plan a Garden Salad. There are no strikes, and a **Skip tutorial** button is on every pop-up.
- **The Friday Night: Plan & Serve (primary gameplay mode):** Acts 2 and 3, from 5:00 to 10:00 PM on the shift clock, with every mechanic active: throwing, catching, hazards, a new pot station, and scripted events such as the waiter tripping and the shelf collapsing.
- **Shell menus:** the main menu, settings, the pause menu, Nana's note pop-ups, and the Results / Game Over screen. In all of these the game is paused and the player cannot affect the kitchen.
- **Competition mode:** single player against the game system. There is no multiplayer. The only competition with other people or yourself is the saved high score and the star rating.

6. Game World

Kitchen Rush covers these game world dimensions:

- **Physical:** one small diner kitchen in a closed room with solid walls. Ingredient crates are on the back wall, the stove on the left, two chopping boards on the right, a center island with the plate rack and trash bin, and the pass window on the front wall. Every station is a 2 to 3 second walk away.
- **Temporal:** one Friday night from 5:00 PM to 10:00 PM on a shift clock that runs on world time, one in-game hour per 60 seconds of world time. Time itself is also the main mechanic, because it speeds up and slows down with you.
- **Environmental:** a cheerful, pastel low-poly diner with a checkered floor, Nana's handwritten notes taped around the kitchen, and a jukebox and dining-room murmur heard through the pass.
- **Emotional:** warm, hectic, and a little silly, never scary. Standing still should feel calm, and walking should feel urgent.
- **Ethical:** there are no enemies and no one else gets hurt. Hazards only hurt the cook, customers are never shown as characters (they just leave if you take too long), and the waiter's mistakes are clumsy, not malicious.

7. Background & Story

You inherited your grandmother's diner, **The Second Hand**, and it owes three months of rent. Tonight is the town's Friday dinner rush, your one shot to earn enough in tips to keep the doors open. Nana left you one more thing: her brass pocket watch. Wind it, and the world holds its breath while you stand still. Nana ran this kitchen alone for forty years, and now you know how.

Her handwritten notes are still taped around the kitchen, and they are the tutorial, written in her voice ("Time waits for a cook who stops to think"). Gus, the diner's loyal but clumsy waiter, shouts orders through the pass and causes most of the night's disasters. At closing, the tips jar is counted against the rent: surviving the night saves the diner (1 star), and a great night means Nana would be proud (2 to 3 stars).

8. Progression From Beginning to End

- **Act 1, Nana's Notes (about 3 minutes):** the clock is frozen at 5:00 PM. You learn that time follows movement, make a Tomato Salad, cook a steak by pacing in place, and plan a Garden Salad.
- **Act 2, The Dinner Rush (5:00 to 7:30 PM, about 2.5 minutes):** you learn to throw and catch, tickets pile up (up to 3 at a time), the pot opens at 5:30 PM with a soup order, and Gus trips at 6:00 and 6:30 PM, sending knives, hot sauce, and steaks flying.
- **Act 3, Closing Time (7:30 to 10:00 PM, about 3.5 minutes):** the shelf collapses at 8:00 PM, a chain reaction around 8:30 PM forces you to throw the pan to knock a boiling pot off the burner, and at 9:40 PM Nana's Special asks for a steak dish and a soup at once.
- **10:00 PM:** the Results screen shows your tips, a 1 to 3 star rating, and your high score. Losing all your health or getting 3 strikes ends the night early.

Each act is split into short beats so there is always something new within 30 seconds or so, and the whole game takes about **10 minutes** of real time, since players slow time down to think.

9. Platform

Kitchen Rush is a single-player PC game made in Unreal Engine 5.8 (C++, First Person template). It is built for **Windows (x86)** and played with a keyboard and mouse.